



What is the most transparent way of communicating your priorities within a strategic planning process?

All strategic planning processes involve priority setting because resources are limited. Traditionally, text-based strategic plans identify a set of priority strategies for the coming planning period. By definition, these priority strategies will almost always be a subset of what could potentially have been focused on.

This traditional text-based strategic planning approach suffers from two problems. The first is that anyone wanting to critique such a strategic plan needs to understand whether the particular priorities selected are the most important ones. To do this, they need to build a model in their heads of alternative priorities. Once they have done this, they then need to compare the strategic plan's actual priorities with the alternatives. Success doing this relies on the completeness of their mental model of alternative priorities. If it is patchy, then they can't robustly critique the strategic plan. The second problem is that strategic plans built in this way need to be substantially rewritten every time priorities change. This limits how agile an organization can be in response to a changing strategic environment.

In contrast to the traditional approach, it's better to use a DoView strategy/outcomes diagram as the basis for strategic planning. Once such a diagram is constructed, priorities are mapped directly onto the boxes within it as shown in the Setting Priorities On a DoView Strategy/Outcomes Diagram Tool (C1). First, this is better than the traditional text-based strategic planning approach because it's much easier to critique whether the right priorities have been selected. In DoView strategy/outcomes diagrams, you always include all steps and outcomes, not just current priorities (see the DoView Drawing Rules (B7)). Therefore, any reader of any DoView strategy/outcomes diagram can immediately see not only what boxes have been selected as current priorities, but also what boxes are not being identified as priorities at the moment. This is in contrast to the traditional planning approach where the reader would have to think these alternatives up themselves.

Second, planners can easily change priorities in later planning periods by simply changing the priority markings on boxes within the DoView. The DoView Planning approach is much faster, more transparent, critiquable, and agile than the traditional strategic planning approach.